

A PRABHAKAR RAO



ALTERNATIVE: The Front wants to break the mould of national politics not be deprived of their land."

The matter is not of SEZs alone. Whether it is sharing of river waters, investments in irrigation projects or giving a fresh thrust to agriculture, they are talking in discordant voices. Past experiences show that it is difficult for the coalescing parties to evolve and adhere to a common minimum programme. But they have the advantage of time and the new front can draw up its features well ahead of the 2009 polls. However, it can run into rough weather if the communists were to join them at some stage.

Meanwhile, these parties have to share their other concerns that include issues relating to agriculture, before they can spell out their agenda. "Both the Congress and the BJP have failed miserably in their role as national parties. The regional parties too are willing to help in national development and we are taking important steps in that direction," says Naidu.

What cannot be glossed over is the fact that all these parties are waiting eagerly to improve the image and build their clout. After the recent drubbing in the Uttar Pradesh assembly elections, Mulayam cannot find many takers for his argument that a grand alliance of regional and state-level parties is poised to change the "*taqdir aur tasvir*" (fate and face) of politics in the country.

Marginalised in Haryana after a crushing defeat in the 2005 assembly elections, INLD supremo Chautala is only clutching at the straws by joining the new entity. It is essentially a desperate gambit to keep himself in the reckoning in the state politics. Besieged by the corruption cases being investigated by the CBI against him and his sons—his apparent Ajay Singh and Abhay Singh, Chautala is finding it difficult to recover the political ground, even in his own constituency, in the face of an aggressive wooing of the Jats by Congress Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda. "Our opponents may dub it as an alliance of the defeated chief

ministers, but the Third Front is very much in the national interest," says Chautala, insisting that people are now fed up with both the major parties—the Congress and the BJP. Ironically, while in power, Chautala, who was an ally of the BJP, never concealed his contempt for a 'third alternative'.

For the ageing Jat chieftain there is no option. The INLD, that has banked on BJP's support in the past, may be mortified to discover that it will be marginalised further when BJP joins hands with the dissident Congress faction, led by Bhajan Lal, waiting for an opportune time to break away to form another regional party.

The AGP and its chief Brindaban Goswami are in a somewhat similar predicament. After badly losing two Assembly elections and the breaking away of its most influential leader, Prafulla Mahanta, the party has almost become defunct. Besides, whatever hardline regional issues that were close to the heart of the Assamese middle class, including infiltration from

Bangladesh and invasion by the outsiders (including the Biharis) that the AGP used to highlight, have been hijacked by Congress Chief Minister Tarun Gogoi. The emergence of the Assam United Democratic Front is also making it difficult for Goswami to keep his party afloat.

His move is perhaps to pre-empt Mahanta from joining the new entity, just like Babulal Marandi's JMM will try to keep out Shibu Shoren's Jharkhand Mukti Morcha. They and other constituents, like V. Gopalaswamy's MDMK and P.C. Thomas's Kerala Congress (J), have more to gain by being a part of the front, than contribute to its evolution.

The new front has to show that it is a viable alternative. As Jayalalithaa puts it: "We are neither power hungry nor power seekers. We want to build a well-knit viable front." For the moment, the Third Front is living on the hope that it will be third time lucky.

with Farzand Ahmed, Ramesh Vinayak, Subhash Mishra, Kulaya and Peer Mohammed

For the moment this network of regional parties is living on the hope that the Third Front will be third time lucky.

they are actually clear about at this stage is the policy pursued by the UPA. "The prime minister himself admitted that the real benefits of the present economic policy could not reach the common man. A wrong and skewed policy was to be blamed for the price rise and burden on the common man. Farmers too were getting a raw deal. There was decline in agricultural growth and not many farmers were willing to take to agriculture, as it was not profitable. We cannot allow this to happen and we need to pump in more subsidies," explains Jayalalithaa.

Evidently, the new front plans to take time in framing its alternative economic policy, as it has to be presented as a vote-grabber. It is also trying to build a consensus on the creation of the Special Economic Zones (SEZs). But not all stand in unison. Former Haryana chief minister Om Prakash Chautala wants it to be scrapped. "The SEZ policy is a huge scam by the colonisers. We want a policy to develop the Manufacturing Investment Regions, instead," he says. While V. Gopalaswamy of the MDMK is in favour of SEZs as he feels that "they are in the direction of national development but says that the farmers should